Phil George

NEH Project Site Visit Report Sept. 14, 1975

Mexican Independence Day Celebration East Chicago and Gary

Schedule-

Left Bloomington with Dr. Dorson about 5 am and arrived at motel in Merrillville about 9 am. Checked in, changed, met with Richard, and left for Main St., Indiana Harbor, East Chicago. Arrived at Supermercado Mexico about 10. We learned at the Supermercado that the parade was not to start until noon so we began to walk the length of Main and then over to Deodor St. to Church of Nuestra Senora De Guadalupe. Then back up to the cars to watch parade. It began about 12 noon and finished about 2 pm. We had lunch in the Supermercado and then drove to Block Stadium for the afternoon's activities of Mexican song, dance, food, Charros, greased pole climbing event, soccer game, etc. About 4 pm we went back to the motel. Notes written, clean up, and preparations for the Fiesta Patria in Gary that night.

We arrived at Marquette Park Pavillion around 7 pm and were told no food would be served so we left to eat at Pepe's, then back to the Pavillion. We witnessed the coronacion of the Queen and the performance of El Baile Folklorico Azteca. We arrived at the motel again about midnight.

Observations-

I need to get in touch with the Union Benefica Mutualista in East Chicago which sponsored the day's activities and the Sociedad Mutualista, Mexico in Gary which sponsored the Fiesta Patria in Gary.

Also I will check out the two Botanicas on Main Street in the Harbor.

The two Mexican markets in the Harbor may in fact serve as the main gathering places for the Latinos in the area.

The printing shop may have a lot of information on the Harbor, at least, since they publish the local Spanish newspaper.and do the posters for up-coming events.

Comments:

The whole day was really a comedy of errors. The newspaper article upon which we based our moves, while correct in the general statements, was in error in all of the specifics. The time of the parade was wrong. There was no mention of the Block Stadium program. The cost of tickets and the serving of food at the Fiesta Patria were in error. At each crucial turn we had to check on the Newspaper article's accuracy. I'm not sure if that is a function of problems with the paper or with the groups releasing the information. I will need to check a number of sources before making major trip plans for special events.

Indiana Daily Student
Tues. Sept 16, 1975 p 3

Fiesta

photos/Marilyn Moores

Last weekend, East Chicago staged a two-day commemoration of the Mexican Independence Day. Above, traditionally clad celebrants made music, danced and observed the merry activities. Right, a young boy usurps the current American hat craze with a foreign version – the sombrero.

Region joyfully celebrates Mexican Independence Day

By Marilyn Moores
ids Staff Writer

"Viva La Virgen de Guadalupe, Viva Mexico, y viva la independencia!"
– Father Hidalgo, Sept. 16, 1810
Dolores, Mexico

EAST CHICAGO – These are the words that started the Mexican War of Independence against Spain in 1816. They were again shouted at midnight Monday as East Chicago's Mexican citizens as well as first and second generation Americans joined to celebrate the Mexican Independence Day.

The actual celebration took place Saturday and Sunday in the form of dances, a parade, singing dance groups, speakers and a soccer game.

Many of I.U.'s Mexican-Americans as well as other students of Spanish descent drove to East Chicago to participate in the celebration. "To me it means a day of unity and celebration not only for Mexican-Americans but for all Latin people," said Efrain Montantes, an I.U. junior majoring in Latin American Studies.

La Union Benefica Mexico (UBM) a neighborhood association for Mexican-Americans was the scene of Saturday's dance and the crowning of the queen of the fiesta.

Tiny children, giggling adolescents, college students home for the weekend, somber matrons and their spouses all danced to live Mexican music and many sang along with "La Bamba" and "Ay, Jalisco, No Te Rajes, (Oh, Jalisco, Don't Give Up). Among the older people not a word of English was heard, while among the younger people a mixture of Spanish and English predominated.

At 1 a.m. when the lights came on signaling the end of the dance, cries of "Otra" (another song) echoed throughout the dance hall. The crowd thinned slowly as people returned home to prepare for Sunday's desfile (parade).

Preparations for the parade began early Sunday morning as the streets began to fill with people, many in Mexican costumes. Mexico's colors – green, white and red – hung from windows, cars, bicycles and shop windows everywhere.

The parade, made up of the East Chicago Washington and East Chicago Roosevelt High Schools' marching bands, floats sponsored by local merchants, social clubs and soccer clubs, various dance groups and bands, made its way down Main Street as shouts of "Viva Mexico libre" (May free Mexico live) followed.

The parade marched to Block Stadium with the spectators following behind, many waving the red, green and white flag of Mexico. There they filled the stands or bought tacos, tamales or carne con chile from the 20 or so vendors who had set up open air shops.

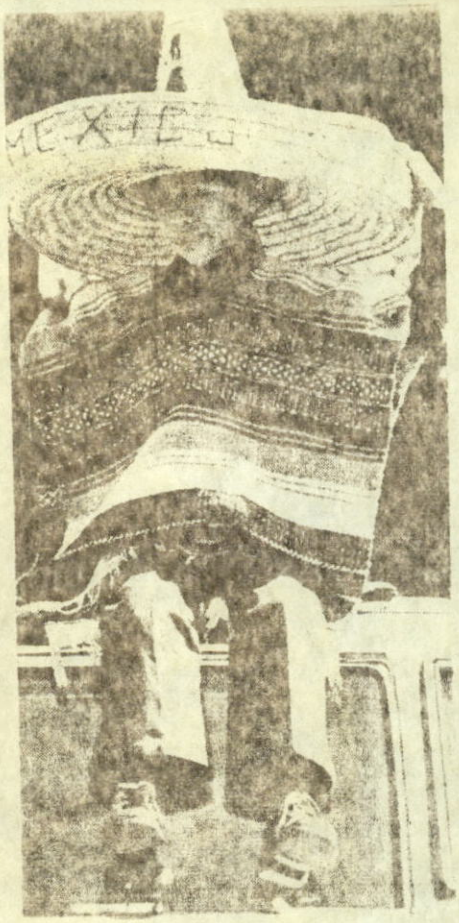
The sound of the mariachi bands filled the air, while Grupo Verduzco, a local dance group pounded their heels to "El Jarabe Tapatio," a Mexican folk dance.

The afternoon climaxed with a soccer match between two amateur soccer clubs.

Competition was stiff and the crowd came alive with every play. Young children imitated the players with their own soccer balls on the sidelines. From the game, the crowd again turned to dancing in what was by then a chilly autumn evening.

The strains of the brass instruments of the mariachis, the smell of the cooking and sounds of voices singing blended together in the night to close East Chicago's salute to Mexico's independence.

"Mexicans seem to love their country more than anyone else in the world," Montantes said. "Mexican-Americans living in this country still follow the traditions and customs of their home country. That explains the enthusiasm of this celebration."



photos/Marilyn Moores

Fiesta

Last weekend, East Chicago staged a two-day commemoration of the Mexican Independence Day. Above, traditionally clad celebrants made music, danced and observed the merry activities. Right, a young boy usurps the current American hat craze with a foreign version – the sombrero.

Region joyfully celebrates Mexican Independence Day

By Marilyn Moores
ids Staff Writer

"Viva La Virgen de Guadalupe, Viva Mexico, y viva la independencia!"
– Father Hidalgo, Sept. 16, 1810
Dolores, Mexico

EAST CHICAGO – These are the words that started the Mexican War of Independence against Spain in 1810. They were again shouted at midnight Monday as East Chicago's Mexican citizens as well as first and second generation Americans joined to celebrate the Mexican Independence Day.

The actual celebration took place Saturday and Sunday in the form of dances, a parade, singing dance groups, speakers and a soccer game.

Many of I.U.'s Mexican-Americans as well as other students of Spanish descent drove to East Chicago to participate in the celebration. "To me it means a day of unity and celebration not only for Mexican-Americans but for all Latin people," said Efrain Montanez, an I.U. junior majoring in [illegible]

neighborhood association for Mexican-Americans was the scene of Saturday's dance and the crowning of the queen of the fiesta.

Tiny children, giggling adolescents, college students home for the weekend, sober matrons and their spouses danced to live Mexican music and many sang along with "La Bamba" and "Ay, Jalisco No Te Rajes" (Oh, Jalisco, Don't Give Up). Among the older people [illegible] word of English was heard, while among the younger people a mixture of Spanish and English predominated.

At 1 a.m. when the lights came on signaling the end of the dance, cries of "Otra" (another song) echoed throughout the dance hall. The crowd thinned slowly as people returned home to prepare for Sunday's desfile (parade).

Preparations for the parade began early Sunday morning as the streets began to fill with people, many in Mexican costumes. Mexico's colors – green, white and red – hung from windows, cars, bicycles and shop windows everywhere.

The parade, made up of the East Chicago Washington and East Chicago [illegible]

The parade marched to Block Stadium with the spectators following behind, many waving the red, green and white flag of Mexico. There they filled the stands or bought tacos, tamales or carne con chile from the 20 or so vendors who had set up open air shops.

The sound of the mariachi bands filled the air while Grupo Verdazco, a [illegible] dance group pounded their heels to "El Jarabe Tapatio," a Mexican folk dance.

The afternoon climaxed with a soccer match between two amateur soccer clubs.

Competition was stiff and the crowd came alive with every play. Young children imitated the players with their own soccer balls on the sidelines. From the game, the crowd again turned to dancing in what was by then a chilly autumn evening.

The strains of the brass instruments of the mariachis, the smell of the cooking and sounds of voices singing blended together in the night to close East Chicago's salute to Mexico's independence.

"Mexicans seem to love their country more than anyone else in the

Region joyfully celebrates Mexican Independence Day

By Marilyn Moores
ids Staff Writer

"Viva La Virgen de Guadalupe, Viva Mexico, y viva la independencia!"
— Father Hidalgo, Sept. 16, 1810
Dolores, Mexico

EAST CHICAGO — These are the words that started the Mexican War of Independence against Spain in 1816. They were again shouted at midnight Monday as East Chicago's Mexican citizens as well as first and second generation Americans joined to celebrate the Mexican Independence Day.

The actual celebration took place Saturday and Sunday in the form of dances, a parade, singing dance groups, speakers and a soccer game.

Many of I.U.'s Mexican-Americans as well as other students of Spanish descent drove to East Chicago to participate in the celebration. "To me it means a day of unity and celebration not only for Mexican-Americans but for all Latin people," said Efrain Montantes, an I.U. junior majoring in Latin American Studies.

La Union Benefica Mexico (UBM) a neighborhood association for Mexican-Americans was the scene of Saturday's dance and the crowning of the queen of the fiesta.

Tiny children, giggling adolescents, college students home for the weekend, somber matrons and their spouses all danced to live Mexican music and many sang along with "La Bamba" and "Ay, Jalisco, No Te Rajes, (Oh, Jalisco, Don't Give Up). Among the older people not a word of English was heard, while among the younger people a mixture of Spanish and English predominated.

At 1 a.m. when the lights came on signaling the end of the dance, cries of "Otra" (another song) echoed throughout the dance hall. The crowd thinned slowly as people returned home to prepare for Sunday's desfile (parade)

Preparations for the parade began early Sunday morning as the streets began to fill with people, many in Mexican costumes. Mexico's colors — green, white and red — hung from windows, cars, bicycles and shop windows everywhere.

The parade, made up of the East Chicago Washington and East Chicago Roosevelt High Schools' marching bands, floats sponsored by local merchants, social clubs and soccer clubs, various dance groups and bands, made its way down Main Street as shouts of "Viva Mexico libre" (May free Mexico live) followed.

The parade marched to Block Stadium with the spectators following behind, many waving the red, green and white flag of Mexico. There they filled the stands or bought tacos, tamales or carne con chile from the 20 or so vendors who had set up open air shops.

The sound of the mariachi bands filled the air, while Grupo Verduzco, a local dance group pounded their heels to "El Jarabe Tapatio," a Mexican folk dance.

The afternoon climaxed with a soccer match between two amateur soccer clubs.

Competition was stiff and the crowd came alive with every play. Young children imitated the players with their own soccer balls on the sidelines. From the game, the crowd again turned to dancing in what was by then a chilly autumn evening.

The strains of the brass instruments of the mariachis, the smell of the cooking and sounds of voices singing blended together in the night to close East Chicago's salute to Mexico's independence.

"Mexicans seem to love their country more than anyone else in the world," Montantes said. "Mexican-Americans living in this country still follow the traditions and customs of their home country. That explains the enthusiasm of this celebration."